

INORGANIC

Chemical substance that is not based on the element carbon.

INSECTIVORE

An animal that feeds on insects.

INTERNAL FERTILIZATION

In reproduction, a form of fertilization that takes place inside the female's body. Internal fertilization is a characteristic of many land animals, particularly insects and vertebrates.

KEEL

In birds, an enlargement of the breastbone that is anchored to the muscles that are used in flight.

KERATIN

A tough structural protein found in hair, claws, and horns.

LARVA (PL. LARVAE)

An immature but independent animal that looks completely different from an adult of the species. A larva develops the adult shape by metamorphosis; in many insects, the change takes place in a resting stage that is called a pupa.

LAVA

Molten rock that has erupted from a volcano, and then hardens.

LEGUME

Plants of the pea family of flowering plants, the Fabaceae. They are important for having root nodules that contain nitrogen-fixing bacteria.

LEK

A communal display area used by male animals (particularly birds) during courtship. The same location is often revisited for many years.

LICHEN

Mutualistic association between a fungus and a photosynthetic alga. From this relationship, the fungus obtains sugars, and the alga obtains minerals.

LIFE CYCLE

The developmental sequence of an organism from gametes (sex cells) to death.

LOCOMOTION

Movement from place to place.

LUSTRE

The shine or look of a mineral due to the reflection of light off its surface.

MAGMA

Rock in a molten state and lying below Earth's surface.

MAGNOLIIDAE

Group of flowering plants consisting of four orders with certain primitive characteristics, such as undifferentiated tepals instead of sepals and petals.

MANDIBLE

The paired jaws of an arthropod, or, in vertebrates, the bone that makes up all or part of the lower jaw.

METABOLISM

The complete array of chemical processes that takes place inside an animal's body. Some of these processes release energy by breaking down food, while others use energy, for example, by making the body's muscles contract.

METAMORPHIC ROCK

Rock that has been changed by heat, pressure, or both to form new rock consisting of new minerals.

METAMORPHOSIS

A change in body shape undergone by many animals – particularly invertebrates – as they grow from being a juvenile to an adult. In insects, metamorphosis can be complete or incomplete. Complete metamorphosis involves a total shape change during a resting stage, which is called a pupa. Incomplete metamorphosis involves a series of less drastic changes, and these occur each time the young animal moults.

MIGRATION

A journey undertaken to a different region, following a well-defined route. Most migratory animals move with the seasons to take advantage of good breeding conditions in one place, and a suitable wintering climate in another.

MIMICRY

A form of camouflage in which an animal resembles another animal or an inanimate object, such as a twig or a leaf. Mimicry is very common in insects, with many harmless species imitating ones that have dangerous bites or stings.

MINERAL

An inorganic, naturally occurring material with a constant chemical composition and regular internal atomic structure.

MITOCHONDRION (PL. MITOCHONDRIA)

Granule inside the cell of a eukaryote used for respiration. Mitochondria use up oxygen to release energy.

MOLAR (TOOTH)

In mammals, a tooth at the rear of the jaw. Molar teeth often have a flattened or ridged surface, and deep roots. They are normally used for chewing.

MONOCOTS (MONOCOTYLEDONS)

Group of flowering plants with a single seed leaf (cotyledon).

MONOECIOUS

A plant that has separate male and female parts on the same individual.

MONOGAMOUS

Mating with a single partner, either during the course of one breeding season or throughout life. Monogamous partnerships are common in animals that care for the development of their young.

MOULT

The shedding of fur, feathers, or skin so that it can be replaced. Mammals and birds moult to keep their fur and feathers in good condition, to adjust their insulation, or so

they can be ready to breed. Arthropods, such as insects, moult their exoskeleton in order to grow.

MUTUALISM

A relationship between two different species within an ecological community where both species benefit. For instance, a flowering plant and a pollinating insect share a mutualistic relationship.

MYCELIUM

Mass of thread-like hyphae making up the body of a fungus.

MYCORRHIZA (PL. MYCORRHIZAE)

The mutualistic association between a fungus and the roots of a plant. The fungus obtains sugars, while the plant increases its mineral uptake by absorbing minerals via the fungus's extensive mycelium.

NICHE

An organism's place and role in its habitat. Although two species may share the same habitat, they never share the same niche.

NITROGEN FIXATION

A chemical process whereby atmospheric nitrogen is converted into more complex nitrogen-containing substances, such as protein. Nitrogen fixation is undertaken by certain types of micro-organisms.

NODE

The point where two sections of a plant's stem join, from which one or more leaves, shoots, branches, or flowers arise.

NUCLEUS (PL. NUCLEI)

The structure inside the cell of a eukaryote that contains chromosomes.

NUT

Dry, hard-shelled fruit of some plants, usually a single seed.

NYMPH

An immature insect that looks similar to its parents but which does not have functioning wings or reproductive organs. A nymph develops its adult form by metamorphosis, changing slightly each time it moults.

OMNIVORE

An animal that eats both plants and other animals as its primary food source.

OPERCULUM

A cover or lid. In some gastropod molluscs, an operculum is used to seal the shell when the animal has withdrawn inside. In bony fish, an operculum on each side of the body protects the chamber containing the gills.

OPPOSABLE

Able to be pressed together from opposite directions. For example, many primates have opposable thumbs, which can be pressed against the fingers so objects can be grasped.

ORGAN

The structure of a body that carries out a particular function. Examples are the heart, skin, or a leaf.

ORGANELLE

A specialized structure that forms part of a plant or animal cell.

ORGANIC

Chemical substance based on carbon.

OVIPAROUS

Reproducing by laying eggs.

OVIPOSITOR

An egg-laying tube extending out of the body of some female animals, especially in insects.

OVULE

Structure that contains the egg of a seed plant. These are encased in an ovary in flowering plants, but naked in gymnosperms. After fertilization the ovule becomes the seed.

PARASITE

An organism that lives on or in another host organism, gaining advantage (such as nourishment) while causing the host harm. Most parasites are much smaller than their host and have complex life cycles involving the production of huge numbers of young. Parasites often weaken their host but generally do not kill them.

PARTHENOGENESIS

A form of reproduction in which an egg cell develops into a young animal without having to be fertilized, producing offspring that are genetically identical to the parent. In animals that have separate sexes, young produced by parthenogenesis are always female. Parthenogenesis is common in invertebrates.

PECTORAL FIN

One of the two paired fins positioned toward the front of a fish's body, often just behind its head. Pectoral fins are usually highly mobile and are normally used for manoeuvring.

PELVIC FIN

The rear paired fins in fish, which are normally positioned close to the underside, sometimes near the head but more often towards the tail. Pelvic fins are generally used as stabilizers.

PERENNIAL

A plant that normally lives for more than one season.

PERIANTH

The outer two whorls of a flower (the calyx, made up of sepals, and the corolla, made up of petals); especially where the two are undifferentiated.

PETAL

One of the parts of the corolla of a flower. Petals are often brightly coloured to attract pollinating animals.

PETIOLE

The stalk of a leaf.

PHEROMONE

A chemical produced by one animal that has an effect on other members of its species. Pheromones are often volatile substances